The Shifting Paradigm in the Science of Consciousness

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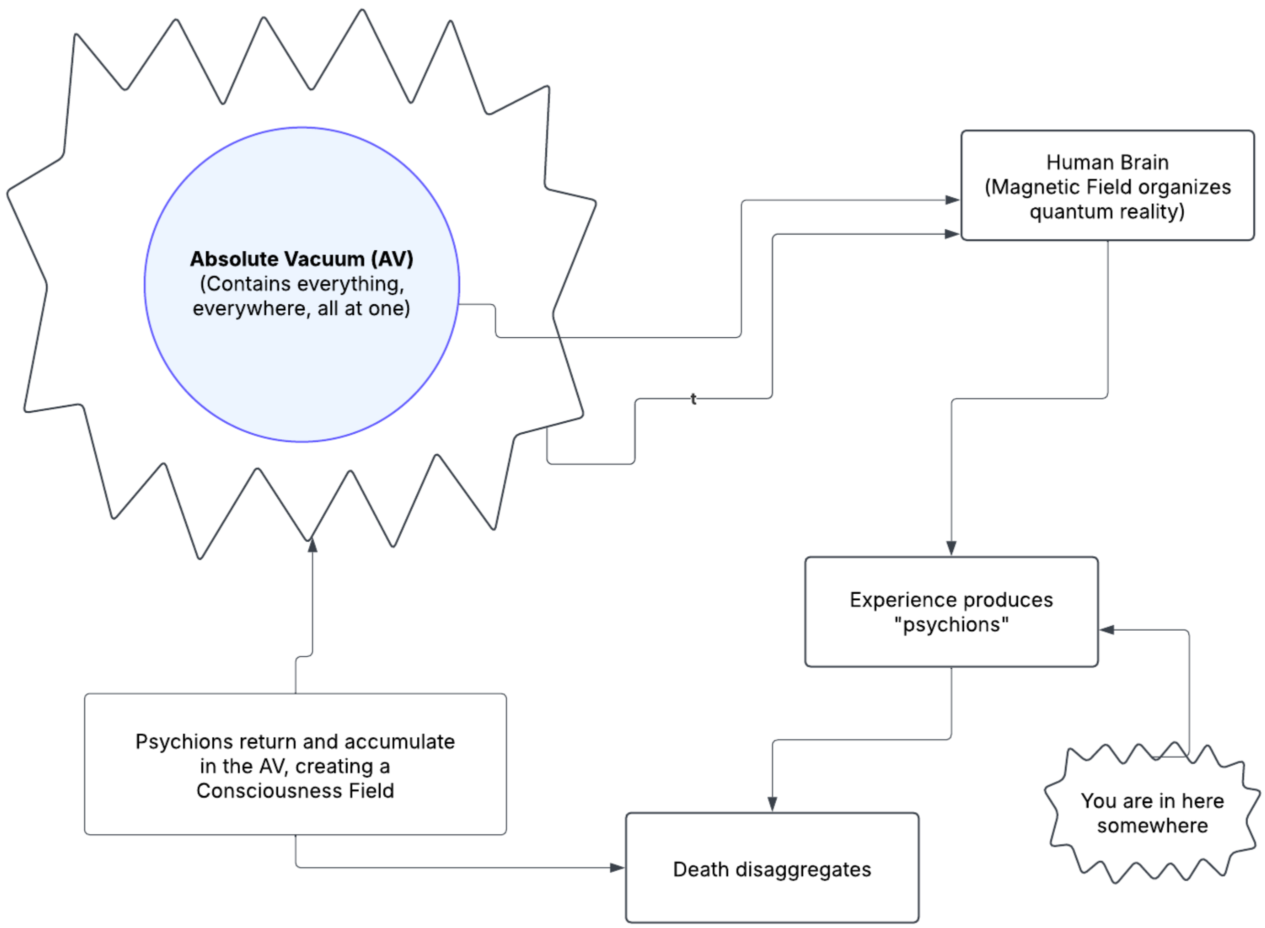
Consciousness Field Theory (CFT)
(Mocombe)



> His religious feeling takes the form of a rapturous amazement at the harmony of natural law, which reveals an intelligence of such superiority that, compared with it, all the systematic thinking and acting of human beings is an utterly insignificant reflection.
> **Einstein, The World as I See It**

Introduction

Who am I?

Who is this “I” that I am aware of?

Who is this “I” writing these words?

Who is this “I” and, importantly, where does it come from?

The question of the nature and source of the egoed human consciousness has been a central puzzle of philosophy since its inception (e.g., Descartes, 1637). Within the paradigm of modern science, the dominant answer has been a materialist one: consciousness exists but is an emergent property rooted in the neurology of the brain and body. This “neuronal computational” view posits that complex calculations within our neural networks generate the phenomenon of subjective experience.

This perspective has always been problematic, even from a strictly scientific standpoint. For one, it completely erases centuries of “mystical” and religious experience that point repeatedly and convincingly beyond a limited bodily consciousness. Two, it ignores anomalous phenomenon which challenged the boxed in view (Lommel, 2010; van Lommel et al., 2001). These phenomenon have been easy to dismiss, however, as pseudo scientific, parapsychologist nonsense. However, there is now a growing body of evidence that suggests that consciousness cannot be neatly located within a single physical unit but may extend beyond it in both space and time. However, there is now a growing body of evidence that suggests that consciousness cannot be neatly located within a single physical unit but may extend beyond it in both space and time (Bem, 2011; Cardeña, 2018; Kelly et al., 2007) .

A Reluctant Shift in the Mainstream

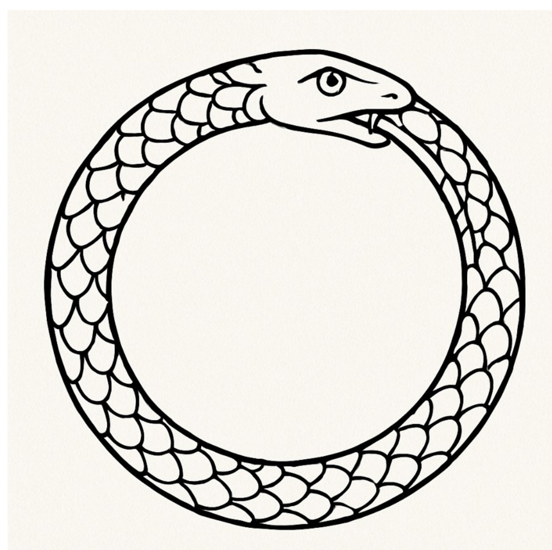
The principles of **quantum mechanics** have long provided a theoretical basis for this beyond-the-body perspective, with **non-locality,** the phenomenon where entangled particles instantaneously influence each other regardless of distance, focusing the core challenge (Einstein et al., 1935). Even in the face of established theory and growing evidence, mainstream views have remained doggedly focused on physical processes located within the physical body.

Recently however cracks in the materialist fortress have become apparent. Scholars are now attempting to develop theories that move beyond strained mainstream views whose brain-bound materialist explanations cannot account for observable phenomenon.

Case Study: The Consciousness Field Theory

One example of this emerging trend is Paul C. Mocombe's "Consciousness Field Theory" (CFT), published in *Advances in Bioengineering and Biomedical Science Research* (2021). While the journal is niche, the appearance of such work in academic literature signals a growing willingness to entertain unconventional models.

Mocombe's theory situates itself explicitly against dualist (read "spiritual" interpretations) while simultaneously stretching materialism to its limits. Building on Orch-OR and John McFadden's CEMI field theory, Mocombe argues that consciousness is not generated by the brain but received by it. In this view, the brain's electromagnetic field functions as the *glue* that binds psychions together into an individuated, coherent ego (Mocombe, 2021). This field is generated by the "periodic discharge of neurons." When psychions enter the electromagnetic field generated by the orgasmic discharges of the neurons, the field then "constitutes" the "mind, practical consciousness, and the self…" (p. 21).



The central claim is this: consciousness is a **fifth force of nature**, composed of quantum particles he names *psychions*.

These particles, not present at the birth of all things (i.e., the Big Bang), emerge later as the universe evolved life. It is life itself, specifically life "experiences" that produce "...produced "the qualia that would constitute the consciousness fields as psychions (Mocombe, 2021, p. 13). To translate, psychions emerge here as the consequence of the collective mash of lived experience, experience which, upon “matter disaggregation” (presumably death) “returns” to the absolute vacuum. The returned psychions thus constitute a “permanent field” (a **Consciousness Field** or CF), which contains, according to the logic of the theory, all experiences ever. This CF thus provides an informational field which contains the “information content of past, present, and future experiences of beings” (Mocombe, 2021, p. 13) can be tapped into at various times, like during “near death experiences, depression, induced prognostic dreams and trances, psychic mediations, and mystical/spiritual or religious revelations.” Access to this Consciousness Field is required to explain observable anomalies in which information appears to persist or transmit beyond the confines of an individual’s limited biological existence (Nahm & Greyson, 2009). By positing psychions that return and constitute a Consciousness Field and then re-emerge from the absolute vacuum as the foundation of “I”, Mocombe accounts for anamolous phenomena without abandoning a materialist register.

It is an interesting theory and it immediately begs interesting questions, like how does the magnetic field “shape” consciousness and can that shaping be altered in some fashion, by drugs or experiences and such? Where does the “I” come from in all this? Is that present at birth or is it developed over time? How is it constituted? To what extent is it determined, by the CF or by experience? Can it be shaped, thereby controlling personality generation?

You get the idea.

If Mocombe’s theory is correct, there’s a world here waiting to be explored.

The model is brilliant and elegant in the way it attempts to bridge neuroscience, quantum physics, and even sociological structuration, but in a materialist fashion. For Mocombe, consciousness is emergent from the materials of the universe, yet it becomes uniquely expressed through human social systems: language, ideology, praxis, and institutional structures. This integration ties his physics of the “consciousness field” directly into his broader philosophical framework of *phenomenological structuralism*.

A Strained Materialism and Human Privilege

Mocombe’s account is deeply ambitious but also internally strained. On the one hand, it maintains a strict materialist register. Consciousness is described as a quantum substance, not a metaphysical spirit (one could reasonably wonder what the difference is). On the other hand, the properties ascribed to “psychions” (sounds suspiciously like midichlorians), including eternal recycling, non-locality, survival beyond death, are indistinguishable characteristics of what spiritual traditions have long described as the soul/atman/higher self. The only difference is that spiritual traditions posit a personality behind the screen. His effort to exclude “superstition” results in what might be described as **crypto-metaphysics**: a rebranded soul theory cloaked in the language of physics.

Moreover, despite invoking the multiverse and cosmic recycling, the model re-centers human consciousness and existence as privileged. Psychions become meaningful only when embodied through a human being. Other forms of consciousness, animal, ecological, or more-than-human intelligences (McSherry & McLellan, 2023; Williams et al., 2022), are all assumed to be imaginary, inferior, and subsequently relegated to an undefined space. Thus, while CFT aspires to a universal account, it risks reinscribing biological chauvinism under a new guise.

Wider Implications and Critical Reflections

The productive turmoil in consciousness studies mirrors broader paradigm shifts in science. The erosion of strict materialism opens new space for integrating anomalous data, near-death experiences, terminal lucidity, and mystical states into scientific discourse. The risk, however, is threefold:

1. **Testability –** Theories such as Orch-OR and CFT must be subjected to rigorous empirical evaluation. Without falsifiable predictions, they risk being dismissed as speculative metaphysics. At present, both models remain under-determined, offering more philosophical frameworks than testable hypotheses. Yet, there are potential experimental footholds, something we may explore at a later date.

2. **Fearlessness –** Progress in consciousness research requires a willingness to confront possibilities that may seem, to the Western European philosophical tradition, uncomfortable or scientifically disruptive. Theorists must resist the ingrained bias of excluding non-materialist explanations *a priori*. Evidence from near-death experiences, terminal lucidity, and quantum non-locality increasingly suggests that the boundaries of consciousness may extend beyond the brain. To dismiss these possibilities or fail to fully explore the implications out of fear of appearing “unscientific” risks stifling genuine discovery. True scientific integrity demands

openness: hypotheses should be evaluated on their explanatory power and evidential support, not on whether they conform to inherited metaphysical preferences.

3. **Repackaging –** In attempting to present themselves as rigorously materialist, some theories of consciousness end up embedding ideological assumptions that serve existing systems of hierarchy and accumulation. The language of Mocombe's Consciousness Field Theory (CFT) exemplifies this: while proposing a universal consciousness field, it nevertheless re-centers the human brain as the privileged vessel of individuation. In this view, psychions only achieve a coherent "self" when filtered through human neuronal microtubules. This quietly reasserts biological chauvinism while denying that other things, other beings, even beings without a body, could possess a recognizable "I" or "We."

From a critical standpoint, this is **ideological reassertion**. The accumulating class historically grounds its power in narratives of hierarchy: humans over animals, elites over commoners, rational "selves" over allegedly irrational or sub-personal beings. By claiming that non-human consciousness lacks person-hood, that it is mere informational flux without subjectivity, CFT reproduces this hierarchy in scientific guise. It affirms that individuality, self-awareness, and agency belong primarily to human actors, while everything else is consigned to the role of background, exploitable substrate. It also reintroduces space for hierarchy. Like the colour of one's blood or one's DNA endowment, certain human actors can have more or less "consciousness" than others.

Such handling of consciousness is doubly flawed. First, it forecloses the possibility that *I-ness* and *We-ness* might be distributed throughout the cosmos and not monopolized by human brains. Second, it fundamentally misrepresents what consciousness actually is: not only a field of information, but a lived, subjective process that always appears *as someone*, a point of awareness with self-recognition.

"I think therefore I am."

An "I" definitely exists.

By erasing this dimension outside the human, CFT inadvertently props up an ideology of hierarchy and unequal worth — precisely when the scientific evidence of non-human intelligence and the phenomenological data of consciousness studies point in the opposite direction.

If science is to truly move forward, it must resist this ideological repackaging. Models of consciousness should not only be open to field-like or quantum accounts but must also take seriously the possibility that subjectivity, individuality, and agency are not uniquely human phenomena. Only then can research escape the gravitational pull of class-bound narratives that have long distorted both science and spirituality.

Conclusion

The science of consciousness is in flux. The old materialist orthodoxy, while still dominant, is increasingly pressured by its own limitations and by anomalous evidence it cannot explain. Mocombe's *Consciousness Field Theory* exemplifies both the promise and the pitfalls of this moment. It extends the scientific imagination beyond reductive brain-based models but risks reintroducing bias and materialist prejudice. The challenge for future research will be to formulate rigorous, testable hypotheses that can adjudicate between competing frameworks, without collapsing back into reductionism or drifting into unfalsifiable metaphysics.

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